

Budget Meal Prep

Cook Once, Eat All Week

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1. INTRODUCTION

If you're tired of spending \$15 on a mediocre lunch or wondering what's for dinner at 6:00 PM, this guide is for you. Meal prepping is for anyone who wants to reclaim their time and keep their hard-earned dollars.

By spending just 2-3 hours on a Sunday, you can ensure that you have healthy, delicious meals ready to go for the next five days.

2. BUDGET SHOPPING LIST

- **Inventory First:** Check what you have before buying more.
- **The Staples:** Stock up on grains (rice, oats, pasta), proteins (beans, eggs, frozen chicken), and hardy veggies (onions, carrots, potatoes).
- **Seasonal Produce:** Buy what's on sale. Swap ingredients based on price.
- **Avoid Pre-Cut:** Chop it yourself to save 50%.

3. THE SUNDAY PREP PLAN

Hour 0: Start your grains (rice, beans, pasta).

Hour 0.5: Chop and start roasting veggies and chicken.

Hour 1.0: Cook ground meats or sauces on the stovetop.

4. ESSENTIAL TOOLS

- **Reliable Containers:** Airtight glass or BPA-free plastic.
- **Sharp Chef's Knife:** Essential for efficient chopping.
- **Large Baking Sheets:** For high-volume roasting.

5. 15 REHEAT-READY RECIPES

Breakfasts

1. Veggie & Feta Egg Bites

BREAKFAST | QUICK REHEAT

Whisk 10 eggs with chopped spinach and feta. Pour into a muffin tin and bake at 350°F for 20 mins.

2. Apple Cinnamon Baked Oatmeal

BREAKFAST | BATCH COOK

Mix 2 cups oats, 2 cups milk, 1 egg, chopped apples, and cinnamon. Bake in a square pan at 350°F for 35 mins.

3. Banana Bread Overnight Oats

BREAKFAST | NO-COOK

Mash a banana in a jar with 1/2 cup oats, 1/2 cup milk, and a pinch of walnuts. Refrigerate overnight.

Lunches & Dinners

4. Turkey & Sweet Potato Chili

LUNCH/DINNER | FREEZER FRIENDLY

Brown ground turkey, add diced sweet potatoes, canned beans, and tomatoes. Simmer for 30 mins.

5. Sheet Pan Chicken & Root Veggies

LUNCH/DINNER | EASY PREP

Toss chicken cubes, carrots, and potatoes in oil and rosemary. Roast at 400°F for 25 mins.

6. Black Bean & Corn Quinoa Bowls

LUNCH/DINNER | PLANT-BASED

Cook quinoa. Mix with black beans, corn, salsa, and lime juice. Great cold or warm.

7. Honey Garlic Tofu Stir-Fry

LUNCH/DINNER | PLANT-BASED

Sear cubed tofu, add frozen veggies and a soy/honey sauce. Serve over prepped rice.

8. Lentil "Bolognese" Pasta

LUNCH/DINNER | HEARTY

Use cooked lentils instead of meat in a standard marinara sauce. Toss with whole wheat pasta.

9. Peanut Noodle Salad

LUNCH | BEST COLD

Cold noodles tossed in peanut butter, soy sauce, and sriracha with shredded cabbage.

10. Beef & Broccoli Skillet

DINNER | HIGH PROTEIN

Sliced flank steak or ground beef sautéed with garlic, ginger, and broccoli.

11. Mediterranean Chickpea Salad

LUNCH | NO REHEAT

Chickpeas, cucumbers, tomatoes, and red onion in a lemon-herb dressing. Keeps for 4 days.

12. Salsa Verde Chicken Casserole

DINNER | COMFORT FOOD

Shredded chicken, brown rice, salsa verde, and a sprinkle of cheese. Bake until bubbly.

13. Curried Chickpea & Spinach Stew

DINNER | FLAVORFUL

Canned chickpeas simmered in coconut milk and curry powder with fresh spinach added at the end.

14. Pesto Pasta with Cherry Tomatoes

LUNCH | SIMPLE

Whole grain pasta tossed in pesto with halved cherry tomatoes and white beans.

15. Turkey Burger Bowls

DINNER | LOW CARB OPTION

Ground turkey patties (crumbled) served over lettuce with pickles, onions, and a side of roasted potato wedges.

6. STORAGE & SAFETY

- **Cool First:** Let food stop steaming before closing lids to prevent sogginess.
- **The 4-Day Rule:** Most prepped food is best eaten within 4 days. Freeze anything for later in the week.
- **Labeling:** Always mark your containers with dates.

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